

Political Economy in the Global South

ECO 4200, Spring 2023

Villanova University

Instructor: Dr. Laura Meinzen-Dick (laura.meinzen-dick@villanova.edu; she/her; will generally respond within 24 hours on weekdays and 48 hours on weekends)

Office Hours: TR 12:30 – 2:30 and by appointment, Bartley 3055A (Zoom OH available by appointment)

Class Meeting Times: TR 2:30 – 3:45 Bartley Hall 2046

Course website: [Blackboard](#)

Course Description:

Economic development, and improving the lives of the world's poor, requires economic and policy tools to address market failures, poor service delivery, and weak institutions. However, these tools often need a functioning, benign government to implement them – which may be lacking in poor countries. In this course, we will examine economic development when governments don't work or aren't well-intentioned: when corruption, low accountability, state capture and misaligned incentives hinder development. Studies of political economy in the global south look at how governments select and incentivize both politicians and bureaucrats, as well as reforms attempting to improve government functioning.

This course also aims to explore empirical methods of causal inference commonly used in political economy work. The first half of the course will be structured around these methods, introducing a method and how it is used before turning to an in-depth discussion of a key paper using the method. This part of the course will improve your skills as informed consumers of empirical economic research as well as familiarize you with important topics in the political economy of developing countries. In the second half of the course, we will turn to other topics in political economy that are particularly interesting to you. Groups of students will lead discussions on topics they are interested in; we will also discuss as a class what topics, regions, and concepts you would like to explore.

Prerequisites: ECO 2101, ECO 2102, and ECO 3137.

Required Textbook: *[The Effect: An Introduction to Research Design and Causality](#)* by Nick Huntington-Klein (available for free online or in print) will be used for causal inference methods reading. I will also post required readings, generally academic articles or adaptations, to Blackboard, which may include chapters from other econometrics books.

Required Software: [Stata 17SE](#) is available for all Villanova students through the [Software Portal](#). Stata has an extensive [Youtube channel](#) with useful instructional videos; I will also hold periodic optional Stata tutorials to help with the learning curve.

Course Organization: This class is primarily discussion-based, with some lectures (primarily on empirical methodology at the start of the semester) and work in Stata throughout. You will need to read the required readings before class, so that you can participate fully in discussions with your classmates. I will expect you also to bring your laptop (with Stata installed) to class. Regular attendance and participation are crucial to do well in this class, and factor into your final grade.

COVID-19 and our Classroom: This course is designed as an in-person course; however, there may be occasions when you cannot attend under the [University Excused Absence Policy](#), including circumstances prompted by the pandemic. If this is the case, let me know in advance (or as soon as possible), and we will arrange for you to make up any missed work. I will not in general be recording this class, to encourage full participation within the course.

The CARITAS Commitment is our pledge, as Villanovans, to modify our behaviors to ensure the health and safety of the community. We all need to do our part to keep community members healthy and safe. This shared responsibility – to be considerate of others and to comply with health and safety requirements – is at the heart of the CARITAS Commitment. In this class, we will protect our community by wearing masks at all times.

Statement of Academic Integrity: All students are expected to uphold Villanova's [Code of Academic Integrity](#). Examples of academic dishonesty include cheating, fabrication of information, assisting in or contributing to academic dishonesty, plagiarism, submission of the same work for more than one class, unsanctioned collaboration, misrepresentation, forgery, taking credit for work done by others, stealing or damaging library books, or unlawfully copying computer software. Any incident of academic dishonesty will be reported to the Dean of the appropriate college for disciplinary action. For the College's statement on academic integrity, you should consult the Student Guide to Policies and Procedures. You may view the University's Academic Integrity Policy and Code, as well as other useful information related to writing papers, at the [Academic Integrity Gateway website](#).

Learning Support Services: There is a wealth of resources available at Villanova to help you succeed in this and all your courses; I would encourage you to take advantage of them, even before you feel you need them.

- Villanova Writing Center: The [Villanova Writing Center](#) provides one-on-one sessions (either virtual or in-person) with a qualified tutor. You may come to the Writing Center at any point in your writing process: with an outline, rough draft, or just your ideas, and they will work with you at your own pace. Working with the Writing Center will improve your research project.
- Center for Speaking and Presentation: The [Center for Speaking and Presentation](#) provides free guidance and meetings to Villanova Students to help improve your presentation skills and manage speaking anxiety. Working with their experts will improve your presentations, regardless of your level of comfort in presenting.
- Office of Disabilities and Learning Support Services: It is the policy of Villanova to make reasonable academic accommodations for qualified individuals who have specific learning needs and for students with disabilities. You can register with the Learning

Support Office and present verification by contacting learning.support.services@villanova.edu or the [Office of Disability Services](#) at 610-519-4095. Please notify me of accommodations that will help you in the first two weeks of the course.

- Learning Support Services also provides academic support services, workshops, and one-on-one sessions in university-relevant skills such as time management, study strategies, academic reading, learning styles, test taking, and test anxiety. Students of *all abilities*, including successful students who want to enhance their academic skills and students who are struggling, are welcome to use these services which are free of charge and open to all registered Villanova students.
 - The Office of Disability Services is the primary office with specialized knowledge and experience in physical disability issues; they will facilitate necessary accommodations.
- Falvey Memorial Library: The library's [website](#) serves as the portal to online and on-campus services and resources. You are encouraged to [contact](#) the Library's [subject librarians](#) for resources that will help on the research project, including available data sources and scholarly journals and books.
- The Learner's Studio: [Villanova Learners' Studio](#) provides free 1:1 and small group content tutoring for on campus courses. From quick homework clarification questions to prep for final exams, they can help! Pop in as-needed or book a regular weekly session; walk-ins are welcome or tutors for a particular course can be booked in advance online.
- Mathematics Learning Resource Center: The [MLRC](#) offers tutoring support for freshman and sophomore level math courses as well as space to study together on group projects. This is particularly helpful for refreshers on earlier math courses that upper-level economics courses build upon. They also offer a math computer lab and an on-site library to help you study independently and at your own pace.
- Technology Support Services for Students: If you have any issues with technology in this course, particularly in accessing Stata, contact [UNIT](#). They also offer a variety of services to Villanova students.
- University Counseling Center: The [University Counseling Center](#) provides professional counseling to help students function optimally with regard to emotional, academic, social and psychological issues. National surveys reveal that 30% of college students report having felt "so depressed it was difficult to function" at some time during the past year; 20% of college students reported that overwhelming anxiety negatively affected their academic performance, and 4.6% have considered suicide during the past year. If you are experiencing any of these issues, know that you are not alone and that the Counseling Center can help you through confidential counseling. I am always more than happy to provide an introduction to the Counseling Center if you would like.

Diversity Statement: Villanova University, as a Catholic Augustinian Institution of higher education, recognizes diversity as an integral component of the teaching and learning experience and as an essential element of the ongoing intellectual, social and spiritual development of every member of the Villanova community. Accordingly, Villanova University will be a diverse community. We commit ourselves to cultivating an academic environment marked by genuine curiosity about different perspectives, ardent receptivity to knowledge generated through

intercultural connections and a genuine sensitivity to the variety of human experiences marked by domestic and global differences.

Course Requirements and Grading: There will be no formal exams for this class, given its unique capstone nature. Instead, your performance will be evaluated based on your participation in class (both in-class discussions as well as reading quizzes and attendance), take-home assignments, a class discussion that you and a group will lead, as well as an individual research project of at least 15 pages and a presentation on that topic. The weights of these components to your final grade are given as follows:

	Due date	Weight
Research Project & Presentation	In class & Tues, May 9	50%
Group-led Discussion	In class	15%
Assignments	Announced in class	15%
Participation (Discussions, Reading Quizzes, etc)	In class	20%

Late Work: The schedule of assignments is designed to allow us to progress through the content of the course, which does build on earlier topics. In particular, deadlines allow me to provide feedback on your work (especially the research project) so that you can incorporate my suggestions and improve your paper. However, I understand that circumstances may arise (including mental health) which make a particular deadline difficult for you to meet, particularly as we adapt to this stage of the pandemic. If you feel you cannot meet a particular deadline for an assignment, please let me know as soon as possible. If you let me know in advance of the deadline, there will be no grade penalty so long as you submit the assignment before your adjusted deadline. If you do not let me know in advance of the deadline, there will be a penalty of one letter grade (10%) per day late on that assignment. Please make every effort to meet research project deadlines as listed in the syllabus, so that I can provide timely feedback on your work.

Research Project: A key component of this class is an individual research paper of at least 15 pages that presents empirical analysis of a political economy question of your choosing. The project will be due in stages throughout the term; compliance with intermediate due dates will also be reflected in the grade for the project. These intermediate steps will also allow me to provide more detailed feedback on your research and suggestions. In particular, a proposal will be due in the first half of the semester; if this proposal does not indicate how you will successfully complete the requirements of the paper, I will ask you to resubmit. I will provide details on the required structure, content, and length of each part as the semester progresses. This paper must use regressions for hypothesis testing (using the statistical analysis program of your choice), but the topic and data source are open so long as they are related to political economy and you use causal inference methods. I would encourage you to work with the Writing Center throughout the writing process. You will also present this paper to your classmates at the end of the semester, in a 10 minute presentation with 5 minutes for questions.

Group-led Discussion: After spring break, we will turn to other topics in political economy determined by the class. Groups of approximately 4 students will lead an approximately 30-

minute discussion on a journal article in political economy. Each group will choose a topic and an academic article (in consultation with me) to assign to the class, and will prepare discussion questions to guide the conversation in class.

Assignments: Several take-home assignments will be given throughout the semester. These will cover the causal inference empirical methods we will discuss, as well as practicing implementing and interpreting these methods using real data in Stata. You may work with your classmates to complete these assignments, but any work you turn in must be your own. I will give more detail about these assignments in class.

Participation: As this is a senior capstone class with a small number of students, active participation in class is absolutely critical in this course. I will expect you to have done the assigned reading before class begins, and to engage with the discussion thoughtfully during the class period. Therefore, your regular attendance is necessary for your success. I will give short quizzes at the start of every class with assigned reading to ensure attendance and timely reading. I will drop your lowest two quiz grades in calculating your final grade. I will also be evaluating your participation in discussions during class, including the discussions led by your classmates, small group discussions, individual responses, feedback and questions for your classmates, and whole class discussions. As mentioned above, if you cannot attend class for some reason, please let me know as soon as possible. Please be respectful and courteous to your fellow students and your professor. In particular, please do not use your cell phones during class, as they remove your attention from the discussion.

Grading Scale: Final semester letter grades will be assigned based on the weighted percentages detailed above. To be fair to all students, there is NO additional extra credit in this course. Rounding up or down is based on class attendance and participation. The letter grade distribution will be:

93 – 100: A

90 – 92.99: A-

88 – 89.99: B+

83 – 87.99: B

80 – 82.99: B-

78 – 79.99: C+

73 – 77.99: C

70 – 72.99: C-

<70: D

Tentative Schedule of Topics:

Date	Topic	Assignment Due
T 1/17	Intro and overview of political economy	Install Stata
R 1/19	More on development & political economy	
T 1/24	Econometrics & Stata Review	
R 1/26	Discussion of Films	
T 1/31	Randomized Control Trials	
R 2/2	Corruption	
T 2/7	Instrumental Variables	
R 2/9	Conflict	
T 2/14	Difference-in-Differences <i>Project Proposal/Topic</i>	
R 2/16	Ethnic Favoritism	Problem Set 1
T 2/21	Regression Discontinuity	
R 2/23	Institutions	Problem Set 2
T 2/28	The Research Process <i>Literature Review</i>	
R 3/2	Prealysis plans	Proposal + dataset
T 3/6	Spring Break	
R 3/10	Spring Break	
T 3/14	<i>Project Clinic</i> <i>Data Section</i>	Problem Set 3
R 3/16	Temporal Regression Discontinuity <i>Empirical Strategy</i>	
T 3/21	5 minute presentations	
R 3/23	Customary Institutions <i>Analysis</i>	Literature Review
T 3/28	Group Discussion	
R 3/30	TBD	Data Set
T 4/4	Group Discussion	
R 4/6	Easter Break	
T 4/11	Group Discussion	Empirical Strategy
R 4/13	TBD	
T 4/18	Group Discussion	
R 4/20	Presentations	Analysis Section
T 4/25	Presentations	
R 4/27	Presentations	

T 5/2	Presentations	
R 5/4	Final wrap-up	
T 5/9		Paper Due

Detailed course schedule attached (note that this is subject to change throughout the semester; the most updated schedule including readings will be posted on Blackboard).